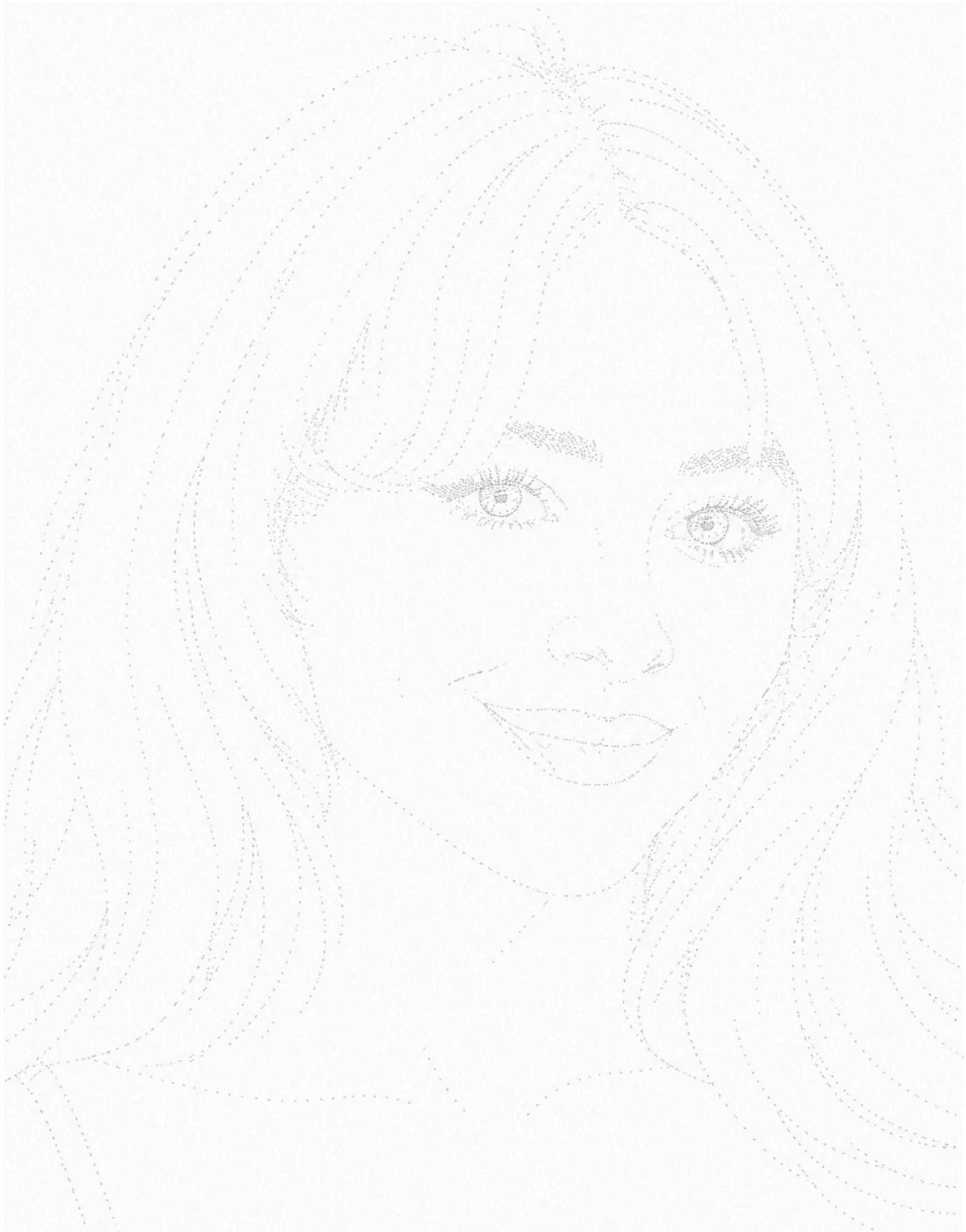


Line art — print at A4, 100% scale. Personal practice use.



Portrait Guide # 021



Difficulty Advanced Est. time 10–14 hours

Subject A person with long voluminous curly hair worn down, warm-toned light skin, a calm serene expression, wearing a bright sky-blue silk top.

Pencils Prismacolor Premier

• MATERIALS

Two ways to work this guide. Every pencil number below is a Prismacolor Premier number — the 24 set covers the roles, the 150 set covers the exact numbers. Each step also names what its key pencil is *doing*, so a substitution never breaks the sequence.

Starting out

Prismacolor Premier Colored Pencils — Set of 24, Portrait Colors — the skin colors this guide uses (warm mid-light, cool dark, warm earth, saturated accent) all exist in the 24. Where a step or garment names a number you don't have, swatch with whatever you like or close.

Strathmore 300 Bristol, vellum surface, 9×12 — vellum tooth holds the layer counts below; smooth plate clogs in half the layers.

If you want the exact set-up

Prismacolor Premier, 150 set — every pencil number in this guide comes from this set, so nothing needs substituting.

Legion Stonehenge drawing paper — a softer, more forgiving tooth that takes more layers before it fills, and burnishes to a smoother finish.

Either way: kneaded eraser · electric eraser · a colorless blender. **No solvent** — every blend in this guide is dry.

• COLOR PALETTE



Ginger Root

PC1084

primary warm skin base, very light orange, dominant throughout lit planes



Beige Sienna

PC1080

warm light skin highlight, red-orange undertone for luminosity



Light Umber

PC941

warm midtone shadow for depth, brown-orange for core shadow areas



Nectar

PC1092

warm light mixing, red-orange for shadow transitions and reflected light



Metallic Gold

PC950

warm light for cheekbone and highlight mixing, golden undertone



70% French Grey

PC1074

warm-leaning cool shadow, defines planes without ashy grey, crisp terminator edge



30% French Grey

PC1070

very light cool-neutral for soft edges and boundary diffusion



70% Cool Grey

PC1065

neutral shadow mid-value, contact shadows on garment and neck



90% Cool Grey

PC1067

dark cool for crisp shadow edges, background depth, lash line support



Sky Blue Light

PC1086

THE measured garment hue (sky blue silk), reflects onto neck and jaw as ambient bounce



Cloud Blue

PC1023

cool undertone for forehead and cheekbone (per artist notes 'cool inside warm'), fold shadows in garment



Ultramarine

PC902

deep cool blue for iris depth, cool sclera, shadow intensity



Pale Sage

PC1089

near-white neutral highlight, soft edge diffusion, subtle background



Sand

PC940

very light golden warm for hair highlights and catch-lights



White

PC938

peak highlight burnishing, specular catch-light, final burnish pass



Cream

PC914

soft highlight, burnishing base, value map foundation, warm near-white



Chocolate

PC1082

warm dark for hair core, lash line support, warm-leaning depth



Black Cherry

PC1078

cool dark for hair core, iris pupil, cool-leaning shadow depth



Blue Lake

PC1102

cool blue for garment fold shadows and depth

• VISUAL ANALYSIS

LIGHT & SHADOW ANALYSIS

Light source direction

soft, diffused light from upper front-left, creating gentle graduated shadows with no harsh terminator lines

HIGHLIGHT

forehead apex, cheekbone peaks, nose bridge and tip, upper lip, chin prominence

LIGHT AREA

lit side of face (right side), lit planes of cheek and temple, upper portion of neck

MIDTONE

transitional zones around cheek, temple, side of nose, jaw plane turning away

SHADOW

core shadow under chin, side of face (away plane), interior of eye socket, underside of jaw

CAST SHADOW

soft shadow cast by head onto upper neck, very gentle

Edge quality notes

terminators are soft and graduated on rounded planes (cheeks, forehead) due to soft diffuse light; form is readable from VALUE separation, not edge crispness; edge hierarchy must be established (ONE sharp focal accent at lash line, everything else loses softness outward)

• STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

OI Value Map — Establish Light & Dark Range

entire face and neck

light circular strokes, even pressure across all zones, warm-neutral monochrome foundation

Light pressure

- Colored pencil is non-liftable; value carries form more than local colour, so a light-pressure monochrome pass establishes the full range before any local colour is introduced. This is the structural skeleton.
- Using PC914 Cream at LIGHT pressure (pencil gliding, not pressing), map the lightest highlights: tiny peak on the forehead dome, cheekbone peaks, nose bridge and tip, upper lip centre, chin point. Leave these as the brightest whites (paper showing through the cream).
- Same pencil, same light pressure: establish midtones on the cheeks, temples, and transitional zones around the nose and jaw. The pencil should still be sliding easily; no area should reach darker than ~50% value.
- Mark the core shadows under the chin and on the side of the face (away plane) with barely more pressure, just enough to read as a shadow shape. Never reach toward heavy darks now; tooth is finite and must hold 15+ more layers.
- The result: a light, warm-neutral map where every zone from highlight to shadow is visible, but nothing is dark. This preserves the paper's tooth for all subsequent glazes.

COLORS ● PC914 Cream

↔ PC914 Cream is doing light warm mapping — any very light pale yellow (Lemon Yellow, Canary Yellow) or cream works; the goal is light and neutral-warm, never grey

STOP WHEN

all zones (highlight, midtone, shadow) are visible · the pencil is sliding across the paper without resistance or drag

✦ *This step is the difference between a portrait that holds luminosity and one that turns muddy: light value map = tooth preserved. Heavy early pressure = mud and nowhere to go. Discipline yourself to glide.*

02 Skin — Base Warm & Cool Variety

entire face (lit and shadow planes)

light, even, directional passes following plane contours; cool layered into warm at light pressure, blended but not overworked

Medium-light pressure

- Artist notes state 'cool variety inside warm skin — especially forehead, cheekbone and jaw'. This prevents the flat, uniformly ruddy effect and keeps skin luminous. The strategy: land a warm outer envelope, then introduce subtle cool accents INSIDE it at forehead, cheekbone, and jaw line. The cool is quiet — the warm still reads as primary — but it prevents monotony and suggests subsurface scatter and form.
- FIRST PASS: Warm base on lit planes. Using PC1084 Ginger Root at MEDIUM-LIGHT pressure (pencil still gliding, not dragging), layer an even, light pass across the lit side of the face: forehead, upper cheek, bridge of nose, upper lip, chin. Follow the contour of the planes with your strokes. This lands the dominant measured skin tone (#e4cbb2, very light warm orange) and establishes the warm envelope.
- SECOND PASS, once the first is set and dry: Cool undertones on forehead, cheekbone, and jaw. Forehead: light touches of PC1023 Cloud Blue at the brow ridge and centre forehead, blended upward with PC1086 Sky Blue Light. The overall reading stays warm (the base is still dominant), but a cool undertone reads as internal form and depth. Cheekbone: light PC1067 90% Cool Grey layered into the warm base on the upper cheekbone, again keeping pressure light so the warm shines through. Jaw plane (shadow side): PC1074 70% French Grey, a warm-leaning cool, sets the away-side plane as distinct from the lit side.
- Do not overwork the cool — it should read as a whisper, not a 50-50 blend. If the cool becomes primary or the skin reads as chalky-cool instead of warmly-accented, the envelope has inverted and you've lost luminosity.

COLORS



PC1084 Ginger Root



PC1023 Cloud Blue



PC1086 Sky Blue Light



PC1067 90% Cool Grey



PC1074 70% French Grey

↔ PC1084 is doing the dominant warm base — any very light warm orange works (Ginger Root, Beige Sienna, Peachy). PC1023 and PC1086 do the cool undertones — any pale blue-teal works (Cloud Blue, Sky Blue Light, Pale Aqua). Do not swap the warm and cool; the role matters more than the exact shade.

STOP WHEN

the warm base is an even, light layer across the lit side · the cool accents are visible but subtle · the pencil is still gliding, not dragging (tooth is not crushed)

✦ *'Cool inside warm' is not 50-50. The warm is the boundary, the cool lives quietly inside. If a face reads as cool-leaning instead of warm-leaning, you've lost the envelope and the whole strategy fails. Less cool than you think.*

03 Skin — Shadows & Depth

core shadows (under chin, around the jaw, side of face away from light)

warm base layer for core shadow; cool crisp edge on terminator; warm reflected light inside shadow; directional strokes following form

Medium for base shadow, light for cool edge, extra-light for reflected light pressure

- Shadows on skin must stay WARM and CHROMATIC — a warm red-orange or olive shadow reads as 'skin in shadow,' while neutral grey reads as 'no light here,' which is a different message. The core shadow must hold a MID-value (not too dark) with a crisp edge where the cheekbone turns, especially on the away plane, so form reads clearly.
- FIRST PASS: Warm shadows. Under the chin and around the jaw, use PC941 Light Umber at MEDIUM pressure, following the soft curve of the neck-to-chin transition. This establishes the core shadow mass. On the side of the face (away plane), layer PC1092 Nectar or PC950 Metallic Gold at light-medium pressure, defining the plane separation with a gradual terminator that reads as form turning away. The shadow stays warm and reads as part of the lit head.
- SECOND PASS, once first is dry: Deepen the core shadow with cool darks where the form is most defined. Along the cheekbone turn (the terminator line between lit and shadow), place VERY LIGHT touches of PC1067 90% Cool Grey — just enough to create a crisp edge between lit and shadow, never a heavy dark. Inside the shadow (where the skin stays warm), layer PC1074 70% French Grey, a warm-leaning cool that darkens without losing warmth. Under the jaw and into the neck, reintroduce PC1092 Nectar or PC1080 Beige Sienna at light pressure for reflected light — the shadow contains a warm glow from bounced ambient light.
- The result: a core shadow that reads as midvalue and warm, with a crisp but narrow cool edge that defines the plane separation. No ashy grey, no muddy blur.

COLORS

● PC941 Light Umber

● PC1092 Nectar

● PC950 Metallic Gold

● PC1067 90% Cool Grey

● PC1074 70% French Grey

● PC1080 Beige Sienna

↔ PC941 is doing a warm midtone shadow — Light Umber, Nectar, Metallic Gold all work. PC1067 is doing the crisp cool edge — 90% Cool Grey, Cloud Blue, Ultramarine work. PC1074 is doing warm-leaning cool for shadow depth — 70% French Grey, any warm-grey works.

STOP WHEN

the core shadow reads as a midvalue, warm plane · the pencil transitions from dragging to gliding (pressure is controlled, not crushing) · the terminator edge is crisp but not heavy

✦ If the away-side plane turns grey or ashy instead of warm, check: (1) Did you start with a warm first pass? (2) Is the cool overlay too heavy? (3) Is the reflected light

warm enough? A failed away plane happens when the initial shadow is not warm enough or the cool overtakes it. Warm first, cool accent — never reverse.

04 Eyes

both eyes

solid pupil block; radial iris strokes; light sclera with NO pure white except specular; lash line hierarchy (upper crisp, lower diffuse)

Heavy for pupil and upper-lid shadow, medium for iris, light for sclera, heavy again for upper lash line pressure

- Eyes are the focal point; they set spatial depth. Pupil + upper-lid shadow first creates a well and depth. Iris built in radial strokes keeps it luminous. Sclera never pure white (light grey-blue or cream, with ONE specular highlight at peak white). Upper lash line is the darkest dark in the eye area and the ONE focal accent that will be kept sharpest in the portrait. Lower lash stays softer and diffuse.
- FIRST PASS: Pupil and upper-lid shadow. Block the pupil solidly with PC935 Black or PC1067 90% Cool Grey at HEAVY pressure, leaving a tiny white fleck at the 11 o'clock position (the specular highlight, reserved for the final step). The pupil should read as a dark, solid well. Upper eyelid shadow (the cast shadow from the lid onto the eyeball): PC1082 Chocolate or PC1078 Black Cherry at MEDIUM-HEAVY pressure, pressing harder here than elsewhere. This shadow creates the depth cue.
- SECOND PASS, once first is dry: Iris and sclera. Iris: using PC902 Ultramarine, make radial strokes outward from the pupil edge toward the iris boundary, creating a gradient from dark (near pupil) to lighter blue (outer iris edge). Blend the outer iris edge with PC1023 Cloud Blue at light pressure, softening the iris-sclera boundary. Sclera (white of eye): very light grey-blue using PC1023 Cloud Blue or PC1089 Pale Sage at LIGHT pressure, never pure white except for the final specular highlight. Upper lash line: re-establish PC935 Black or PC1082 Chocolate, pressing crisp and sharp — this is the FOCAL ACCENT, the sharpest dark in the entire portrait. Lower lash line: PC1074 70% French Grey, softer and more diffuse than the upper lid. Do NOT mirror the upper — keep the lower edge diffuse and soft.
- The eye depth comes from dark pupil + darker upper shadow + light sclera + sharp lash line contrast. The lash hierarchy (upper dark and crisp, lower soft) controls focus.

COLORS

● PC935 Black

● PC1067 90% Cool Grey

● PC1082 Chocolate

● PC1078 Black Cherry

● PC902 Ultramarine

● PC1023 Cloud Blue

● PC1089 Pale Sage

● PC1074 70% French Grey

↔ PC935 and PC1067 both do a dark pupil — Ultramarine, Black Cherry, Black work. PC902 does iris blue — Cloud Blue, Cerulean Blue, True Blue work. PC1023 does light sclera blue — Pale Sage, Cloud Blue work. Do not use pure white (PC938) for the sclera; keep it grey-blue or cream.

STOP WHEN

the iris still shows radial stroke direction (not blended flat) · the upper lash is crisp and sharp, the lower is soft and diffuse · the pupil reads as a dark well with one tiny highlight fleck

✦ *Eyes fail when both lashes are equally dark and sharp — that flattens the eye. The upper lash line is your ONE focal accent for the entire portrait; the lower must stay softer. Also: never ignore that tiny specular highlight in the pupil — it's what makes the eye alive and reflective, not flat and painted.*

05 Lips

lips (upper and lower)

warm base for lips; cool undertone on upper; creases at ultra-light pressure on paper texture only; soft lip line integration

Medium-light for base, light for blending, extra-light for creases pressure

- Upper lip reads darker and cooler; lower lip reads lighter, warmer, and more saturated (it catches the light and is more exposed to light). The lip line stays soft and integrated into the face, never a hard outline. Subsurface scattering makes lips glow warm even in shadow. Fine horizontal creases go in last at ultra-light pressure, just grazing the paper.
- FIRST PASS: Upper lip base. Using PC1092 Nectar or PC1080 Beige Sienna at LIGHT-MEDIUM pressure, layer the upper lip slightly darker and less saturated than the lower. Add a cool shadow on the upper lip where it turns under, using PC1023 Cloud Blue at very light pressure, blending it into the warm base. The upper lip should read as cooler and slightly shadowed.
- SECOND PASS, once first is dry: Lower lip value and warmth. Using PC1001 Salmon Pink or PC939 Peach at MEDIUM-LIGHT pressure, layer the lower lip lighter and warmer and more saturated than the upper. The lower lip catches the light and is more vascularized (more translucent), so it reads pinker and brighter. The lip line itself: do not outline — instead, soften the boundary with the surrounding skin by layering at very light pressure and blending at the edge so the lip integrates into the face.
- THIRD PASS (optional): Fine details and creases. Using PC1074 70% French Grey or PC1067 90% Cool Grey at ULTRA-LIGHT pressure, suggest fine horizontal creases on the lower lip, just catching the paper texture — never carving deep grooves. A subtle shadow on the upper lip, again at ultra-light pressure. The creases should be barely visible, just a suggestion.

COLORS  PC1092 Nectar  PC1080 Beige Sienna  PC1023 Cloud Blue

 PC1001 Salmon Pink  PC939 Peach  PC1074 70% French Grey

 PC1067 90% Cool Grey

↔ PC1092 and PC1080 do the warm lip base — Nectar, Beige Sienna, Peach work. PC1001 and PC939 do the light warm lower lip — Salmon Pink, Peach, Poppy Red work.

STOP WHEN

the lower lip reads warmer and lighter than the upper · the lip line is soft, not a crisp outline · the creases are barely visible, just a texture suggestion

✦ *Lips often go too dark or too carved. Keep them lighter than you think, let the warmth shine, and make the creases SUBTLE — a lip line that is too crisp reads like*

06 Hair — Core Mass & Direction

entire hair mass (long curly hair worn down, one voluminous mass)

long directional strokes following curl fall; density gradient (dense core to diffuse boundary); warm + cool darks; light-to-dark layering; catch-light burnishing last

Medium for core darks, medium-light for mid-tones, light for highlights and edges, heavy only for final catch-light burnishing pressure

- Hair is never flat value. Density gradients (dense at core, thinner at boundary) create form. Warm + cool darks prevent muddy black. Sheen bands and direction follow the growth and twist of curls, not individual strands — the EYE reads the light pattern across the mass, not detail. Paper tooth is a consumable; preserve it by working light-to-dark, never heavy blocking.
- FIRST PASS: Establishing core darks and directional mass. At the crown and where hair enters shadow, build the darkest roots using PC1078 Black Cherry (cool dark) and PC1082 Chocolate (warm dark) in alternating or layered passes at MEDIUM pressure, building density at the very core. Direction: full-length strokes following the fall of the curls, easing pressure toward the tips so the ends stay lighter and thinner. Where curls twist and overlap one another, place PC1074 70% French Grey for depth between clumps — NO pure black, which flattens form. The overall direction is downward and outward with the curl flow, not straight down.
- SECOND PASS, once first is dry: Mid-tones and sheen. Along the lit curves of the curls, use PC941 Light Umber in circular strokes following the curve of each coil, MEDIUM-LIGHT pressure, preserving tooth at the peaks where light hits. Warm highlights on the curls that catch direct light: very light touches of PC1084 Ginger Root or PC940 Sand, directional strokes following the twist of the curl. These highlights sit on top of the mid-tones and suggest shine.
- THIRD PASS (optional): Boundary and catch-lights. Outer boundary of the hair mass: blend the darkest core tones into a diffuse, soft edge using PC1089 Pale Sage or PC1070 30% French Grey at LIGHT pressure, so the hair sits inside the head, not cut out or floating. Catch-light streaks on the shine: burnish PC914 Cream or PC938 White, just a few light strokes at the very end, suggesting the gloss of clean hair. Do not overwork or the hair reads slicked down.

COLORS  PC1078 Black Cherry  PC1082 Chocolate  PC1074 70% French Grey

 PC941 Light Umber  PC1084 Ginger Root  PC940 Sand

 PC1089 Pale Sage  PC1070 30% French Grey  PC914 Cream

 PC938 White

↔ PC1078 and PC1082 do cool and warm darks — Black Cherry, Chocolate, Ultramarine, Dark Brown all work. PC941 does mid-tone brown — Light Umber, Metallic Gold work. PC1084 and PC940 do warm highlights — Ginger Root, Sand, Peach work.

STOP WHEN

the dark core is visibly denser than the outer edge · the strokes follow the curl direction (not straight down or back to front) · the pencil is still gliding on the mid-tone pass

✦ *Hair fails when every layer is the same pressure and direction. Form comes from DENSITY GRADIENT (dense to diffuse) and STROKE DIRECTION (following the coil, not falling straight). Also: press too hard early and the tips flatten into heavy black blobs. Light early, density in the core, diffuse at the boundary.*

07 Neck — Form & Garment Transition

entire neck (full length and width, from jaw to garment, including the transition zone)

warm base for neck form; soft gradual self-shadow under jaw; garment-hue bounce as reflected light at the lower neck

Medium for base, light-medium for shadow, light for bounce pressure

- Neck is a separate plane from the face, with softer form (less muscle definition, fewer landmarks). It has its own self-shadow (soft shadow under the jaw from the head tilting). The garment bounce is critical: sky blue silk reflects up and shifts the skin hue noticeably, so the bounce MUST be the true garment hue (sky blue), not a tint of the face. This grounds the figure in reflected light and light direction.
- FIRST PASS: Neck form and base warm tone. Lit side of neck: PC1084 Ginger Root or PC1080 Beige Sienna at LIGHT-MEDIUM pressure, following the cylinder of the neck, softer than the face (the neck has fewer defined features). Self-shadow under the jaw: PC941 Light Umber (warm shadow) at light-medium pressure, with a soft and gradual terminator — never a crisp line, because the neck is cylindrical and the light wraps around it gently. Where neck meets jaw: soft transition, blending the face and neck tones so there is no hard edge, just a value and temperature shift.
- SECOND PASS, once first is dry: Garment bounce. Lower neck (closest to the garment): light glaze of PC1086 Sky Blue Light — THE measured garment hue — layered over the warm base at LIGHT pressure. This is where the sky blue light reflects onto skin from the silk top. Jaw line just above the garment: trace the bounce up the jawline in very light PC1086, so the sky blue light sits at the neck-face boundary. The bounce must read as reflected light from the garment, not a separate stripe. Keep it integrated and light, but distinct enough that it grounds the figure in ambient light and reflection.

COLORS  PC1084 Ginger Root  PC1080 Beige Sienna  PC941 Light Umber

 PC1086 Sky Blue Light

↔ PC1084 and PC1080 do warm skin base — Ginger Root, Beige Sienna, Peach work. PC941 does warm shadow — Light Umber, Nectar work. PC1086 is the garment bounce (sky blue) — use Sky Blue Light; this is the measured garment hue and should not be swapped.

STOP WHEN

the neck reads as a softer plane than the face · the garment bounce is visible but integrated · the transition from face to neck is soft, not stepped

✦ *Garment bounce is often forgotten or made too subtle. A bright sky blue silk top WILL shift the light on the neck noticeably. If you skip this step or make it too faint,*

the figure floats disconnected from the garment and the light direction reads as unclear. The bounce is a convincing detail that anchors the whole portrait.

08 Garment — Sky Blue Silk Top

visible garment (the sky blue silk top)

horizontal base strokes for drape; fold shadows following fold direction; contact shadow at garment-skin edge; minimal texture lines

Medium-light for base, medium for folds, light for texture pressure

- Garment is a lit form with folds, shadows, and texture — not a fill or flat colour field. White and light colours need fold shadows and contact shadows to read as dimensional fabric, not blank paper. The edge where garment meets skin shows the bounce colour from the previous step. Silk has directional shine and subtle surface texture.
- FIRST PASS: Base garment light. Lit areas of the garment: light, even layers of PC1086 Sky Blue Light (the measured garment hue) at MEDIUM-LIGHT pressure, covering the main visible area. Direction: horizontal strokes following the fabric drape and fold direction, not vertical. This lands the primary sky-blue tone (#a9d4e2, very light cyan-teal) and establishes the garment as the lit form it is.
- SECOND PASS, once first is dry: Folds and dimension. Shadow inside folds (where fabric turns away or overlaps): PC1023 Cloud Blue or PC1102 Blue Lake at MEDIUM pressure, mid-value blue, following the fold line and creating the depth cue. Darker shadows at edges and collars: PC1024 Cloud Blue or PC902 Ultramarine, defining how deep the folds go. Contact shadow (where garment meets skin at shoulder or neck): PC1067 90% Cool Grey or PC1074 70% French Grey, a soft but distinct shadow that grounds the garment to the body.
- THIRD PASS (optional): Detail and silk texture. Silk sheen on the surface: reserve lighter areas (leave paper white or very light blue in peaks where fabric catches light), creating shine. If the reference shows a highlight, burnish PC914 Cream or PC938 White. Wrinkles and fabric texture: suggest with directional lines at LIGHT pressure using PC1070 30% French Grey or PC1065 70% Cool Grey, never overworking into a busy pattern. A few subtle directional lines suggest cloth texture; too many read as fussiness.

COLORS

● PC1086 Sky Blue Light

● PC1023 Cloud Blue

● PC1102 Blue Lake

● PC1024 Blue Slate

● PC902 Ultramarine

● PC1067 90% Cool Grey

● PC1074 70% French Grey

● PC914 Cream

● PC938 White

● PC1070 30% French Grey

● PC1065 70% Cool Grey

↔ PC1086 is the garment base (Sky Blue Light, the measured hue) — use this; do not swap. PC1023 and PC1102 do fold shadows — Cloud Blue, Blue Lake, Ultramarine work. PC1067 and PC1074 do contact shadows — Cool Grey, French Grey work.

STOP WHEN

the garment reads as a dimensional fabric form · the fold shadows are visible but the overall garment is not dark · the texture lines are subtle, not a grid

✦ *A common mistake is leaving the garment flat — even light fabrics need a shadow side and folds to read as 3D. Also: the edge where garment meets skin is where the bounce colour shows; if you forget the bounce, the garment and skin read as disconnected, not unified in the same light.*

09 Detail, Edge Hierarchy & Peak Highlights

entire portrait (focal accent, edge quality, highlight peaks)

sharp focal accent at lash line; softened edges everywhere else; small hard-edged peak highlights at light-catching points via burnishing

Heavy for crisp focal lash line, heavy again for peak highlight burnishing, light for softened edges pressure

- Edge hierarchy controls focus: hard edges advance, soft edges recede. ONE focal accent (the upper lash line) gets the sharpest edge; everything else loses softness outward into the background. Peak highlights on lit planes push value contrast and read as form and light catching the highest points.
- FIRST PASS: Edge hierarchy and softening. Lash line (upper): reinforce with PC935 Black or PC1082 Chocolate at full saturation and sharp pressure, crisp and defined — this is THE focal accent, the sharpest, darkest edge in the entire portrait. Face outline into hair: soften and blend at LIGHT pressure using PC1089 Pale Sage or PC1070 30% French Grey, so the face sits inside the head mass, not cut out. Jaw into shadow: lose the edge with warm shadow tones (PC1092 Nectar, PC941 Light Umber) at LIGHT pressure, blending downward so the jaw fades into the shadow. Hair into background: diffuse boundary, no crisp line — the hair mass should feel integrated into the surrounding space. Garment edge: either lose into background (soft transition) or keep a soft edge with distinct tone separation (garment blue distinct from background), never a crisp outline.
- SECOND PASS, once first is set and dry: Peak highlights on lit planes. Forehead apex: burnish PC938 White (peak highlight) or PC914 Cream with HEAVY burnishing pressure, a tiny spot creating a hard value jump from the surrounding midtone — this reads as the form catching the light directly. Nose bridge and tip: PC938 White highlights, small touches with heavy burnishing, no gradual blend (hard jump = forward-facing form and light catching a prominent point). Cheekbone peaks (where the light grazes the highest curves): PC914 Cream or PC1089 Pale Sage at LIGHT touches, creating the illusion of roundness and light following the form. Chin prominence: if it catches light, small PC914 Cream touch. These highlights are sharp accents, not soft glows; they read as specular reflections on the highest points.

COLORS

● PC935 Black

● PC1082 Chocolate

● PC1089 Pale Sage

● PC1070 30% French Grey

● PC1092 Nectar

● PC941 Light Umber

● PC938 White

● PC914 Cream

↔ PC935 and PC1082 do the focal lash line — Black, Chocolate, Black Cherry work. PC938 and PC914 do peak highlights — White, Cream, Pale Sage work.

STOP WHEN

the lash line is crisp and darker than surroundings, the focal accent · the peak highlights are bright small spots with a hard edge (not blended clouds) · most edges of the face fade softly outward

✦ *The most common edge mistake is making every edge the same softness — a portrait with no crisp focus reads as a photocopy of a photocopy. The lash line IS your focal accent; reserve sharpness there and lose almost everything else. Also: peak highlights are NOT soft glows — they are hard-edged, bright accents on the highest points. The contrast between these crisp spots and the soft edges everywhere else is what makes the portrait read as alive.*

IO Burnish & Wax Bloom Correction

entire portrait (final pass)

heavy burnishing pressure until surface is smooth and waxy; re-layering darks at medium-light pressure; gentle wipe or light fixative for bloom cleanup

Heavy for burnishing (until no texture remains), heavy again for re-darkening darks, light for bloom cleanup pressure

- Burnishing melts the layers into a painted finish, closing the paper tooth. But wax migrates up as a hazy bloom that lightens values and dulls saturation. Removing bloom and re-punching darks is required — not optional — to restore clarity, depth, and the saturation you built underneath.
- **FIRST PASS:** Burnish to close the tooth. Light, even pressure with PC914 Cream or PC938 White (or a colourless blender if available), circular strokes across the entire face and neck, pressing until no paper texture or white flecks remain and the surface feels smooth and slightly waxy. Use **HEAVY** pressure here — the goal is to melt the layers into one unified finish. Garment: burnish with light PC1070 30% French Grey or PC1087 Powder Blue (depending on final garment tone), same light-to-medium burnishing pressure, closing the tooth. Hair: burnish **ONLY** the highlight catch-light areas with PC938 White, not the entire mass — too much burnish on dark hair mutes the depth you built.
- **SECOND PASS,** once burnish is dry: Restore darks. Wax bloom has lightened everything, especially darks. Lash line: re-saturate with PC935 Black or PC1082 Chocolate, sharp and crisp, pushing the value back down after burnish has lightened it. Core shadows (under chin, side plane): re-layer with PC1074 70% French Grey or PC1092 Nectar at light-medium pressure, restoring depth. Hair core darks: re-layer with PC1082 Chocolate and PC1078 Black Cherry, using the same directional strokes from Step 6 to rebuild the density gradient. Fold shadows in garment: re-layer with PC1023 Cloud Blue or PC1102 Blue Lake at light pressure, restoring the fold definition without overworking.
- **THIRD PASS (optional):** Wax bloom cleanup. If a visible haze remains on the surface after burnishing, gently wipe with a clean, soft cloth (microfibre cloth works well) or use a light workable fixative spray, holding 12 inches away, to set the bloom — do **NOT** over-spray or the colours will shift. A gentle wipe often removes the bloom satisfactorily without spray.

COLORS

● PC914 Cream	● PC938 White	● PC1070 30% French Grey
● PC1087 Powder Blue	● PC935 Black	● PC1082 Chocolate
● PC1074 70% French Grey	● PC1092 Nectar	● PC1078 Black Cherry
● PC1023 Cloud Blue	● PC1102 Blue Lake	

↔ PC914 and PC938 do burnishing — Cream, White, Colourless Blender all work. PC935 and PC1082 do restored lash line — Black, Chocolate, Black Cherry work.

STOP WHEN

the surface is smooth and waxy (paper tooth is gone) · the darks are restored to their original depth (lash line, shadows, hair core are back where they were) · a soft wipe reveals no visible bloom residue

✦ *Skipping the 'restore darks' step is the most common mistake at the end. The portrait will look washed out and muddy if you burnish and then stop. Burnishing is NOT the final step; it's the penultimate step, followed by selective re-darkening and then cleanup. The restoration pass takes 15–20 minutes and is the difference between a finished portrait and an incomplete one.*

• WHEN YOU FINISH IT

Leave a comment under the video with a photo of your drawing. I'll run it through the same three lines the AI runs on mine — the verdict, the one thing to fix, and what to target next.

Free. I read all of them, and the ones I answer go in the comments so everyone else can see the same correction.